

Syllabus for Technical Writing, Fall 2026

Last updated August 17, 2026

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For more specific info and specific course policies, see the [Course Policy Manual](#).

Course Details

English 3764: Technical Writing
CRNs #85454, #85455, #85465, & #85467
Fall 2026 (Aug 24–Dec 16)

Course Textbook

Technical Communication
by Markel & Selber. 14th
ed. Bedford/St. Martin's,
2025.



Instructor



Traci Gardner
tengrrl@vt.edu

she, her, hers

Straight, cisgender, white.
Disabled. Night owl. List
maker. Planner addict.

Hoarder of stickers. Lifetime Girl Scout. Hokie
alum. Steelers fan. Poodle lover.

Accessibility

Everyone needs special accommodation at some point. I am happy to work with the [Services for Students with Disabilities \(SSD\) staff](#) or directly with you to make sure that you have the support you need.



Need extra time on assignments?

No problem. If you need more time, use the course's grace period. Check [the Late Policy & Grace Period](#) for more details.

Need a less-distracting environment?

Do your work any place that works for you. All work is done online and independently, so you have complete control over where you work.

Ready to tell me what you need to do well in the course?

Official testing is expensive and time-consuming, so I don't require it. Just let me know what you need by Canvas Inbox or email as soon as possible. SSD's new system gives me access to official accommodation details, but if there's something beyond the forms you want me to know, please message me. Keep in mind I can only apply accommodations moving forward, not retroactively.

Contacting Traci & Getting Help

Questions about the Course & Assignments

HokieBot's Tech Writing Notebook, Fall 2026

Ask your questions in the [Gemini Notebook for the course](#). I have added the course syllabus, course policies, major assignments, and other supporting documents to the Notebook.

Most frequently-asked questions can be answered by searching HokieBot's Notebook. Check here first. It's faster than waiting for Traci to answer your email.



Help from the Writing Center

Visit the [Writing Center](#) on the second floor of Newman Library. You can talk to a tutor if you have a draft, an outline, or just ideas. Bring your assignment description with you. Make appointments online by setting up an account with [WOnline](#) or call the Writing Center director at 540-231-9270.

Questions about Grades, Your Work, and Accommodations

Canvas Inbox or VT.EDU Email

Send your message to tengrrl@vt.edu using your VT.EDU email or using the Inbox tool in Canvas. I will respond as quickly as possible, **usually within 24 to 48 hours on class days**. **I take holidays and weekends off** and reply on the next class day.

Private Online Meetings

Schedule online meetings in Google Meet. Visit my [Booking page](#) to sign up (at least 24 hours in advance). Think of these meetings as like office hours.

Video is not required for the meeting.

Traci's Schedule During the Term

Usually Online Monday to Thursday

- 3 PM to 7:30 PM
- 11 PM to 12 AM

I'm a night owl, so I may reply to your message after midnight.

Offline Weekends & Holidays

Offline after 5 PM on Fridays and all day Saturday and Sunday. I'll send replies on Monday (or the next class day in the case of holidays and university days off).

Course Structure



What's in a Module?

This course has a Module for each class week. Each Module is like a backpack: It includes everything you need for the week. You'll find these materials:

- A Module introduction page
- Details on the readings
- Links to all assignments

To access each module, click on **Modules** in the left menu in Canvas, and then **begin with the Module Introduction page**.

Course Modules

This is a tentative schedule. More information is available in Canvas.

Dates	Week	Topics
Aug 24–Aug 28	Week 1	Exploring Technical Writing Fundamentals
Aug 31–Sep 4	Week 2	Drafting Correspondence & Informational Reports
Sep 7–Sep 11	Week 3	Applying Ethics & Plain Language
Sep 14–Sep 18	Week 4	Drafting User Documents & Applying Document Design
Sep 21–Sep 25	Week 5	Adding Emphasis & Graphics
Sep 28–Oct 2	Week 6	Submitting Your User Document
Oct 5–Oct 9	Week 7	Drafting Proposals
Oct 12–Oct 16	Week 8	Researching Your Project
Oct 19–Oct 23	Week 9	Submitting Your Proposal
Oct 26–Oct 30	Week 10	Writing Recommendation Reports
Nov 2–Nov 6	Week 11	Planning Your Report
Nov 9–Nov 13	Week 12	Drafting Report's Body
Nov 16–Nov 20	Week 13	Drafting Report's Front & Back Matter
Nov 21–Nov 29		Thanksgiving Break
Nov 30–Dec 4	Week 14	Submitting Your Recommendation Report
Dec 7–Dec 9	Week 15	Finishing the Course
Dec 11–Dec 16	Exam Week	Optional Final due by 11:59 PM on Dec 16

Work Categories & Weights

Assignment Basics

This course includes weighted categories of work, described below.

All work is open book. Use the textbook, Canvas, and any notes you have.

Your work is your individual responsibility. There are some group discussions, but you are graded individually, based on your work on these activities.



Kinds of Work in the Course

Your course grade is comprised of two categories (Homework and Major Projects), arranged in six weighted categories, as shown below in Figure 1.

Homework (15%)

These are various short activities, similar to in-class or independent work in a campus-based class. The activities include all of the following:

- Weekly Activities
- Textbook Quizzes
- Draft Self-Checks
- Check-In Surveys

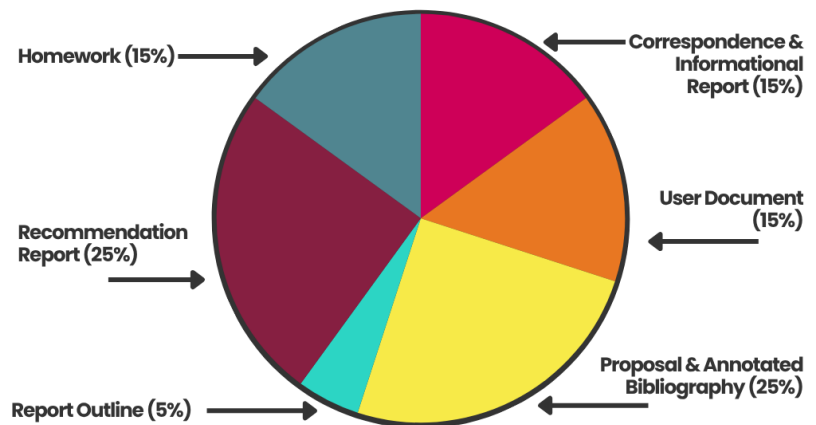


Figure 1. Work Categories and Weight

Major Projects (85%)

These written documents range from 1–15 pages, including visuals. Each project has a rubric that explains how it will be graded. The weight per project varies, as shown below and in the pie chart.

- Correspondence & Short Informational Report (15%)
- User Document (15%)
- Proposal & Annotated Bibliography (25%)
- Recommendation Report Outline (5%)
- Recommendation Report (25%)

Grading Process for Major Projects

Assessing a Document in the Workplace



In the workplace, no one gives you 90% on a report or a B+ on a proposal. You're expected to do the job fully and meet the standards. If something's off, your manager asks you to revise it by the final deadline.

That's what we do in this class. If your work meets the standard, you're done. If not, you can revise it by the revision deadline.

What Is the Standard for Major Projects?

To meet the standard, your major projects need to be ready to send out in the workplace. Generally, major projects you submit need to do the following:

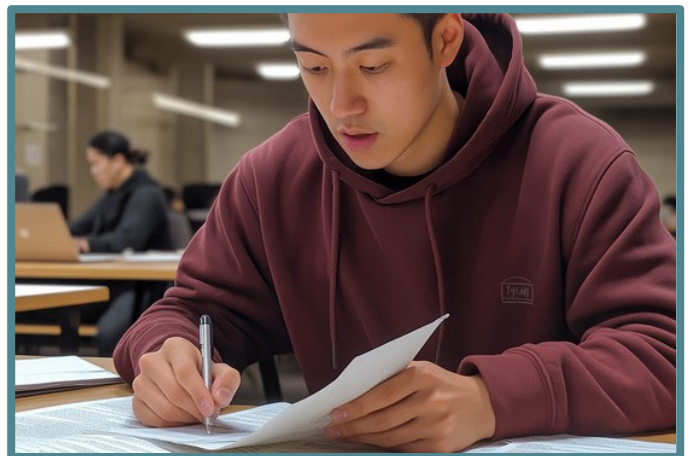
- Be fully available in Canvas before the Grace Period ends.
- Match the assignment's purpose, audience, and situation.
- Follow VT's Honor Code and Principles of Community.
- Meet or exceed all rubric criteria.
- Include all required information and elements.

Each project has a rubric, which calculates the grade for the project. To find expectations for each project, check the assignment and rubric in Canvas.

What If a Major Project Doesn't Meet the Standard?

If your work earns a grade **lower than an A-**, don't panic—it's just a sign that your project needs more work.

As long as you submit your work by the end of the grace period, you can revise and resubmit your project **until you earn 90 (A-)** or until 11:59 PM on the revision deadline, whichever comes first. **Revision grades are capped at 90.**



Grading Process for Homework

A Pass/Fail System (More or Less)

Homework grades generally use a basic Pass/Fail system, following these guidelines:



Complete

You'll earn full credit as long as you

- Submit before the grace period ends.
- Turn in your work in Canvas.
- Upload a readable document in Canvas.
- Meet all basic requirements.
- Respond directly to the assignment.
- Put in a strong effort.



Incomplete

You won't earn credit if you

- Miss the end of the Grace Period.
- Don't submit your work in Canvas.
- Upload an unreadable document.
- Fail to meet the basic requirements.
- Do work unrelated to the assignment.
- Don't put in your full effort.

How Homework Is Graded and Marked in Canvas

Canvas grades most homework automatically (see the table below). When the grade is automatic, I spot-check the work to ensure the grade is accurate. If I notice that you shouldn't have earned credit, I change the grade. If time allows, I may ask you to try again.

Homework Type	Grading System
File Upload	Automatically marked by Canvas when submitted. I then review the work.
Discussions	Manually reviewed and graded.
Textbook Quizzes	Automatically marked by Canvas.
Draft Self-Checks	Automatically marked by Canvas.
Check-In Surveys	Automatically marked by Canvas when submitted, maintaining anonymity.

What Happens When You Earn No Credit?



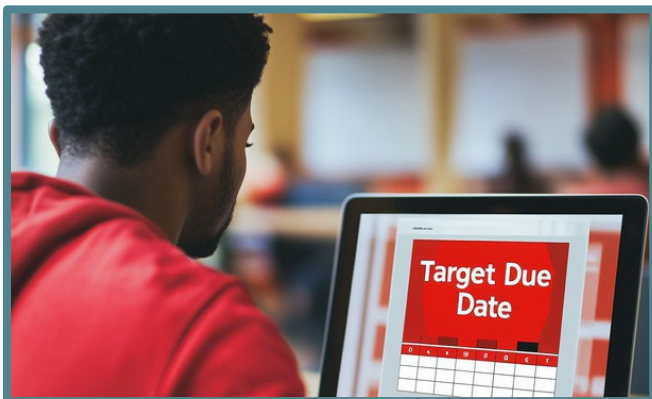
Everything in Canvas is set to have unlimited submissions. If you have not earned full credit (100), you can redo and resubmit your work as long as the grace period is still open.

Virginia Tech Grade Scale with +/-

	B+ 87–89.99	C+ 77–79.99	D+ 67–69.99	
A 93–100	B 83–86.99	C 73–76.99	D 63–66.99	F 59.99 &
A- 90–92.99	B- 80–82.99	C- 70–72.99	D- 60–62.99	below

Late Policy & Grace Period

The Basics



I accept late work for most assignments in this course. Just use the Grace Period.

You don't need to ask in advance or explain why your work is late.

The Grace Period lets you take more time when you need it, as often as you need it, and then turn your work in before the grace period ends.

Target Due Dates

Every assignment in the course has a **Target Due Date**, the date the assignment is due. Aim for the Target Due Date so you do not fall behind. Remember these facts about the Target Due Date:

- It applies to all work in the course.
- It ends most weeks at **11:59 PM on Friday**. Exceptions are Fall Break and the week after Thanksgiving Break.

Grace Periods

All assignments, with one exception, have an automatic extension, called the **Grace Period**. The Grace Period follows these guidelines:

- Lasts **3 weekdays**.
- Requires that work is submitted as a readable document to the relevant assignment in Canvas.
- Ends for each week at 11:59 PM on the Wednesday following the relevant Target Due Date.
- Once the grace period passes, you can no longer submit an assignment and, therefore, it earns a zero.

There is **no grace period for the Final Exam** (which is optional); however, you have the entirety of Exam Week to do your work. Your final exam is due by 11:59 PM on Wednesday, December 16, 2026.

Example Dates

Week 1 Work

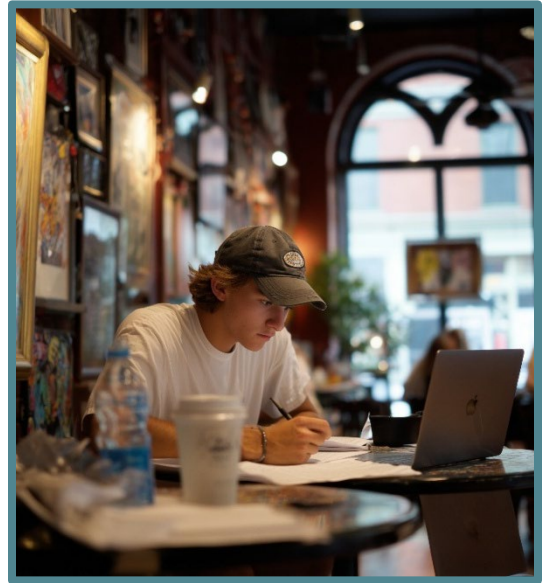
- Target Due Date: Friday, August 28 at 11:59 PM.
- Grace Period: Ends on Wednesday, September 2 at 11:59 PM.

After 11:59 PM on September 2, you can no longer submit work from Week 1.

Major Project Revision Deadlines

You can revise Major Projects as long as you meet these requirements:

- Your Major Project is **submitted as a readable document by the end of the Grace Period**.
- Your submission meets the expectations for a **good-faith effort** (meaning it responds to the assignment and meets basic requirements like topic, focus, length, and format).
- You earn a **grade lower than 90 (A-)** on that Major Project.



Length of Revision Deadlines

You may revise as often as you'd like **until the revision deadline**, which is typically **one week after graded Major Projects are returned**. The Revision Deadline is posted in the Feedback Announcement when grades are posted.

Late Labels and 0 or X Marks in Canvas

If you don't submit your work by the **Target Due Date**, Canvas will do two things:

- Label your work as **Late**.
- Mark it as **0 or F**.

These are automatic actions in Canvas. **There's no penalty** for being late as long as you submit by the end of the **grace period**.

Once you submit the work, I'll check it to see if it meets the assignment criteria. If it does, I'll update the mark to **the letter or number grade**. The **0 or F** will go away. If it doesn't, I'll let you know if you can revise and resubmit. Allow time for me to review and add feedback. It's not automatic.

Unfortunately, the **Late** label is permanent. Canvas won't let me remove it. Try not to stress about it. After all, it doesn't affect your grade.

Key Tips

- You can revise and resubmit during the grace period.
- You're only locked out after the Grace Period ends.
- Canvas doesn't reflect the whole story. Check the assignment or message me if you're unsure.

AI Policies

Does AI Matter in Technical Writing?



An [April 2023 Pew Research Survey](#) found 6 in every 10 Americans (**62%**) said that AI would have a “major impact on workers generally”



75% of global knowledge workers already use AI, according to a 2024 Microsoft/LinkedIn study

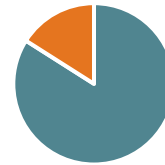
Employees who use AI say it helps them . . .



90% Save time



85% Focus on their most important work



84% Be more creative

Employers say . . .



66% would not hire someone without AI skills



71% would hire less-qualified people with AI skills over more-qualified people without them

Sources

Rainie, Lee, Monica Anderson, Colleen McClain, Emily A. Vogels and Risa Gelles-Watnick. (2023, April 20). [AI in Hiring and Evaluating Workers: What Americans Think](#). Pew Research Center.

Microsoft, & LinkedIn. (2024, May 8). [AI at Work Is Here. Now Comes the Hard Part \(2024 Work Trend Index Annual Report\)](#).

Policy Details

To prepare for the writing you'll do in the workplace, we'll consider how to use AI to improve your critical thinking and writing.

What AI tools can I use?

You can use any [tools approved by Virginia Tech](#) for assignments that require or allow generative AI tasks. The listed tools are officially approved by Virginia Tech because they protect your personal work when you login with your VT PID. They will not use any content you upload, so your writing will not be part of the language learning database.

I will design our activities to be compatible with Copilot to streamline the activities I ask you to complete. You are welcome to use other AI tools that you have access to. If an alternative tool cannot accomplish an assigned task however, you'll need to switch to Copilot.



What can I use AI for in this course?

For each activity, I will provide detailed instructions on how AI can be used. Generally speaking, you can use AI in these ways:

- **Brainstorming Ideas:** You can ask AI chatbots to generate a list of topics that interest you by creating a prompt that includes the assignment parameters. You can also use AI to help you evaluate the brainstormed list for the most promising ideas.
- **Editing Checks:** Have AI check your draft for accuracy. AI chatbots can check for basic grammatical mistakes, punctuation errors, and spelling issues. Ask AI to tell you where the errors are and even what they are, but make updates yourself. Do not have AI correct your work.
- **Research Assistance:** Ask AI to help you research a topic. AI chatbots can help you find relevant sources and gather information. However, it's crucial to verify the accuracy and credibility of the sources and information that AI chatbots suggests. AI does not consistently provide real references. Always make sure the references exist and then cross-check with reliable references.
- **Draft Review:** AI can be used ethically for draft reviewing. You can think of AI as a computer peer review partner. I'll provide instructions for these tasks. I'll ask you to try some of the following AI tasks as you work on drafts:

- **Develop ideas:** AI can help expand on initial ideas, providing additional perspectives or angles that you might not have considered. Use it to deepen your understanding of a topic and develop a more comprehensive approach.
- **Outline and Organize:** AI chatbots can create outlines and organize your thoughts. Input your main points and ask AI to suggest a logical structure or flow for your document.
- **Summarize:** You can use AI to summarize content. This can save time and help you focus on the most critical information.
- **Check Document Design:** Use AI chatbots to review design elements like layout, use of white space, font choices, and design effectiveness. AI can suggest improvements to enhance readability and aesthetic appeal. Be aware however that AI may not accurately analyze visual elements. Verify its suggestions.

What if I want to use an AI chatbot in a way you haven't mentioned?

If you want to use AI in another way, send me a message in Canvas explaining your plan and how it relates to use of AI in the workplace. I'll review your request and let you know if it's acceptable.

Are there things I can't use AI for?

You cannot ask AI to write or revise your drafts or final submissions for you. Using it to review your draft and make suggestions (as described above) is fine. Having AI do the writing or revision for you directly violates the [Cheating and Plagiarism sections of the Virginia Tech Honor Code](#). There may be some exceptions. I'll be clear about these exceptions in the assignments.

What if an AI chatbot gives me incorrect information or makes other mistakes?

Regardless of how or where you use AI in this course, you are fully responsible for the work you submit. Just as in the workplace, you need to stand behind your work. If AI introduces errors and you pass them along, you are accountable for those mistakes. The goal here is not to discourage you from using AI but to help you develop the critical skill of verifying AI-generated content—an essential practice in any professional setting.

What do I need to keep track of when I use AI?

Keep track of what AI tools you used and how you used them. In some cases, the assignment will ask you to save specific artifacts, like the prompt that you used and the response that the AI tool gave you. Always read the assignment carefully to determine the information you need to track as you use AI.

How do I need to acknowledge my use of AI?

When you use AI as you work on your assignments, include details on which AI tools you used and how they contributed to your work in [a submission comment](#) when you submit your work.